# Conceptual Framework: Exchange, Society, and the Himalayan Salt Economy

From social theories of exchange to the historical problem of salt, ecology, institutions, and political authority

## THEORETICAL LENSES

### Mauss

Gift and obligation

Reciprocity sustains ties

### Polanyi

Embedded economy

Reciprocity, redistribution, and householding

### Scott

Subsistence security

Risk and moral economy

### Thompson

Customary rights

Justice and legitimacy

### Parthasarathi

Markets as political projects of state power

## HISTORICAL FIELD

### Western Himalayan Salt Economy

Ecological zones: Changthang, Rupshu, Tso Kar, valleys, passes

Commodity circuits: salt, pashm, wool, grain, tea, livestock

Social institutions: netsang, pastoral mobility, monasteries

Local authority: chu dpon, goba, kotwal, village institutions

Colonial forms: taxation, monopoly, licensing, frontier governance

### Analytical Question

Did salt bind together subsistence exchange, multi-commodity trade, and frontier governance?

### Research Problem

The thesis investigates whether salt connected ecological zones, institutions, and political authority.